

The Plain Dealer | Saturday, November 30, 2002

BOYS BASKETBALL

Rockets say they aren't intimidated by James, Irish

SUSAN VINELLA
Plain Dealer Reporter

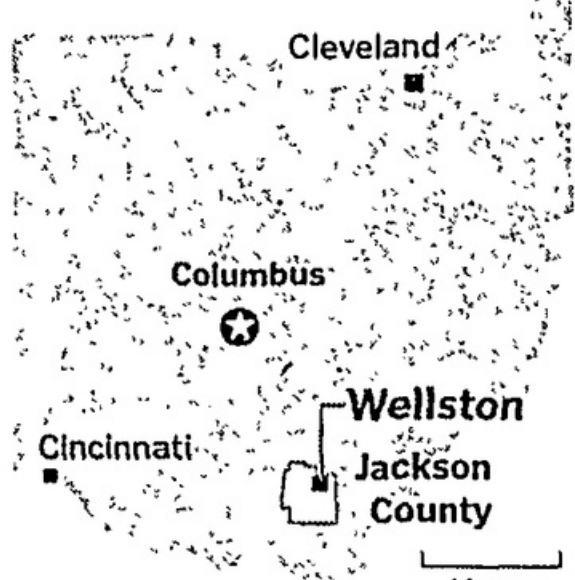
On a boys basketball schedule filled with high school basketball powers such as Virginia's Oak Hill Academy and Columbus Brookhaven, the season-opening opponent for St. Vincent-St. Mary might make fans pause and say, "Wellston who?"

The little-known Wellston Golden Rockets come to Akron today to face LeBron James and the Irish at the school's 1,700-seat gym. The 7:30 p.m. game is sold out and will be broadcast on Time Warner Cable's pay-per-view for \$7.95.

Most think the Division III Rockets will be only an appetizer for the Division II Irish, who face a smorgasbord of highly ranked national opponents this season.

Nevertheless, Wellston coach Jim Derraw promised a battle.

"I'm not going to sit here and tell you we're gonna win," Derraw said. "But we're going to compete. We're not intimidated by any team."



Derraw describes Wellston — an Appalachia town of about 7,000 located 220 miles southeast of Cleveland — as a "real tough town." Founded by a well-known carouser named Harvey Wells in the 1920s, Wellston became known for its bars.

For young boys growing up there, football, not basketball, was the sport of choice. Derraw, a 1976 graduate of Wellston, set out to change that.

To entice more players to the basketball court, Derraw started taking his team to tournaments in the Bahamas, Florida, Las Vegas and Louisville, Ky. The

school also built a 2,100-seat gym with four locker rooms and \$32,000 scoreboards.

For more exposure, Derraw created a one-day holiday tournament called the "National Hoops Classic" at Battelle Hall in Columbus. Two years ago, SVSM played in that tournament against Oak Hill. The two teams were supposed to return again this year, Derraw said, but there were scheduling problems.

Instead of losing them all together, he decided to find a way for Wellston to get on their schedules. For several months, he called SVSM trying to negotiate a deal.

Finally, in July, he had a signed contract that included two non-negotiable provisions: Wellston would receive only 100 tickets and would not receive any proceeds from ticket sales.

Not ideal, but Derraw jumped at it.

"If I start demanding money, I'm out the door," he said. "They can play anyone they want. They were nice enough to allow us to play. We're not gonna push it."

The Rockets finished 15-5 last season and have been to four district finals in Derraw's 15 years as head coach.

They will board a bus at 11 this morning to make the 3½-hour trip to Akron. They'll stop for dinner at Akron's Spaghetti Warehouse before heading to the gym.

Their fans, who paid \$35 for a ticket and transportation to the game, will pile onto two charter buses later in the afternoon to make the seven-hour roundtrip. Some will follow in cars.

What do the Wellston players think about going against James, the best high school player in the country and next year's likely No. 1 NBA draft pick?

"It's gonna be really neat to play against him," Wellston junior guard Jordan Lackey said. "If we beat him, that will be even better."

Tonight: Wellston at St. Vincent-St. Mary, 7:30.

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THE JAMES JOURNAL

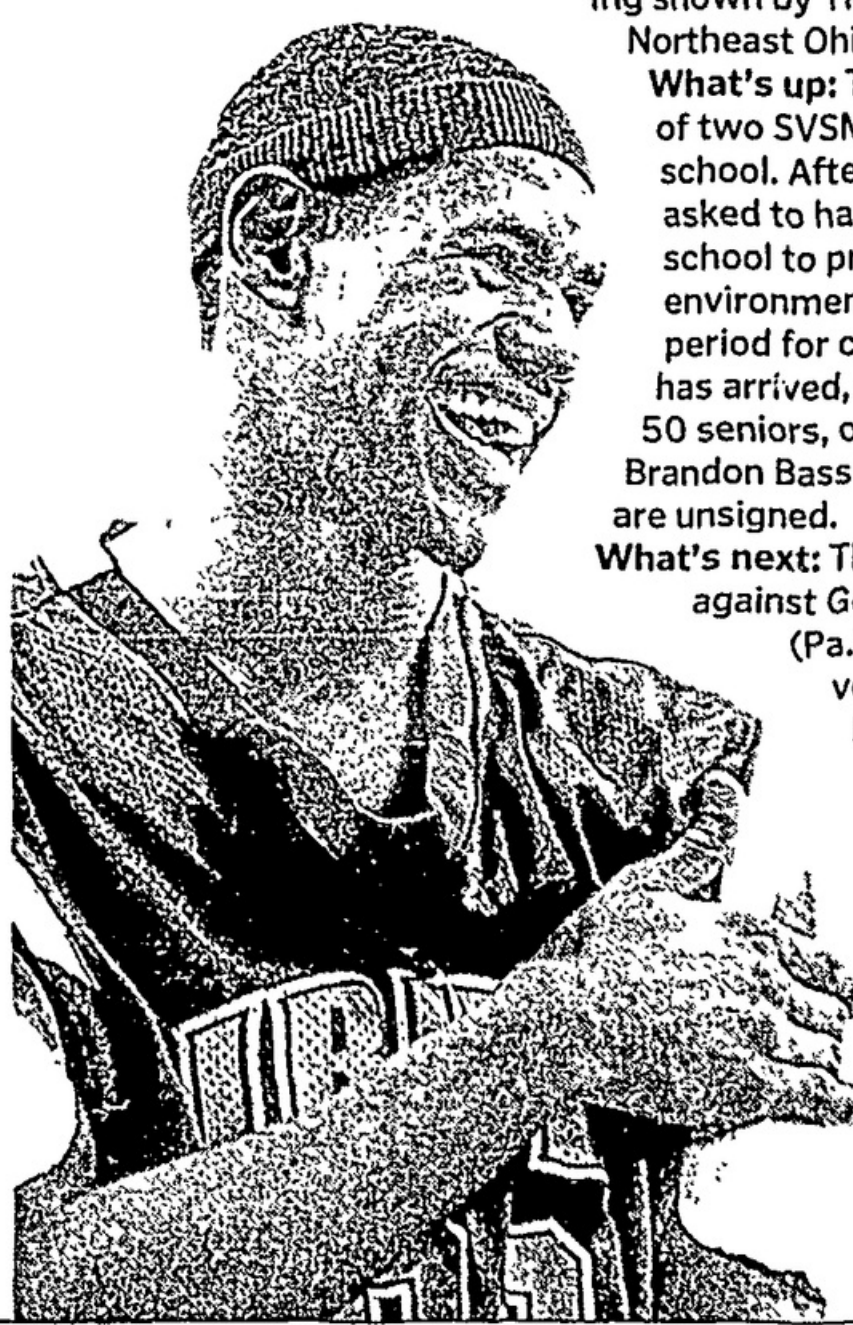
Today's update on LeBron James and the St. Vincent-St. Mary boys basketball team

Today's game: 7:30 p.m. vs. Wellston at St. Vincent-St. Mary High. The Irish's season-opening game, which is sold out, is being shown by Time Warner cable in Northeast Ohio at a cost of \$7.95.

What's up: Tonight's game is one of two SVSM will play at the high school. After last season, players asked to have some games at the school to provide a more intimate environment. . . The fall signing period for college letters of intent has arrived, and of the nation's top 50 seniors, only James and forward Brandon Bass of Baton Rouge, La., are unsigned.

What's next: The Irish play tomorrow against George Junior Republic (Pa.) at 6 p.m. at the University of Akron's Rhodes Arena. George Junior is a reform school for boys 4.5 miles north of Pittsburgh, and it defeated the Irish, 58-57 in overtime, last year. As of Friday, about 1,000 tickets are mailed.

Call the University of Akron box office at 330-972-6920.



BOYS BASKETBALL

Last-second shot propels Bulldogs

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said sophomore forward Corey Sparks was probably his "fifth option" last night.

But the way Donahue's Bulldogs share the basketball, you better defend all five of the kids he puts on the floor.

Olmsted Falls, behind a soft 5-foot jumper along the baseline by Sparks as time was expiring, upset host Warrensville Heights, 77-76, last night in a nonleague boys opener.

"On that play, Steve [junior forward Steve Gansey] tries to take his man off the dribble and somebody has to help out, or otherwise Steve's going straight to the basket," Donahue said after Gansey drove the left side, drew two defenders with him and threw a perfect pass to a wide-open Sparks. "Corey's just a sophomore, but he's so calm. The kid never panics."

Cool and collected while he's playing, Sparks jumped in the air and ran down the court after scoring his only basket of the game. He also hit two free throws for a total of four points.

Warrensville Heights, which has won more than 20 games each of the past three seasons, got some solid play from its reserves and held a five-point lead at halftime. The Tigers led, 43-36, after senior post Darnell James converted an assist from All-Ohio senior forward Dometrius "Mechie" Johnson into a slam-dunk with 5:34 remaining

in the third quarter.

But Olmsted Falls, turning to the scoring and leadership of Gansey, junior guard Dan Binggeli and junior forward Jamar Scales, cut the deficit to three points entering the fourth quarter.

Binggeli scored 23 points, Gansey finished with 22 and Scales scored 12 of his 16 points in the second half. Their efforts offset a game-high 29 points by Johnson.

"This was fun, the way a great high school basketball game should be," Donahue said. "And I really believe I would be saying that even if we had lost by one point."

After baskets by Gansey and Binggeli and two free throws by Sparks, the Bulldogs led, 69-65, with 2:30 left.

But, after Gansey's driving one-hander made it 73-67 in favor of Olmsted Falls, Warrensville Heights made a final run and took a 76-75 lead on a jumper by junior forward Maurice Bachlor with 12.8 seconds remaining.

Following a timeout, Olmsted Falls got the ball in Gansey's hands, and the brother of former Plain Dealer Player of the Year Mike Gansey (now at St. Bonaventure) ran the winning play the way Donahue draws it up in practice.

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: edwyer@pland.com, 216-999-4677

HIGH SCHOOL SCOREBOARD

Football State Finals

Division II

Northland (13-2) 0 7 6 13-26
Cham-Julienne (14-1) 7 14 13 7-41

First Quarter

Cham-Julienne 15 fumble return (Grant kick), 6:57.

North-Stick 1 run (Grant kick), 11:55.

North-Stick 1 run (Spedick kick), 6:32.

Cham-Julienne 21 pass from Turner (Grant kick), 4:40.

Third Quarter

North-Stick 3 run (kick failed), 5:59.

Cham-Julienne 10 run (kick failed), 5:08.

Cham-Julienne 60 run (Grant kick), 2:15.

North-Stick 3 run (Spedick kick), 11:58.

Cham-Julienne 37 run (Spedick kick), 10:25.

North-Stick 9 pass from Ruhl (kick failed), 6:57.

TEAM STATISTICS

First downs 15 21

Run-Yds 30-281 61-313

Passing 6-13-0 19-151

Comp-Att-Int 6-13-0 19-151

Run-Yds 30-281 61-313

Fumbles-Lost 4-4 2-3-2

Penalties-Yds 20-127 15-147

INDIVIDUAL STATISTICS

RUSHING—Portsmouth West, Lens 12-46.

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PASSING—Portsmouth West, Williams 11-109-35.

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ROUNDUP

Cleveland Heights rides Battle's 39 points to win

From staff reports

Cleveland Heights forward Jon Battle started the boys basketball season in a big way last night.

The senior led all scorers with 39 points as the Tigers held off Columbus Mifflin, 84-79, in the Lima Tournament. Battle scored 29 of his points in the first half.

Alex Nixon, a senior forward, scored 14 points for Heights. Corday Ballard scored a team-high 28 for Mifflin.

Mass. Jackson 54, Rhodes 51 Rhodes, ranked seventh by The Plain Dealer, dropped its opener at home. The Rams were outscored in the third quarter, 24-6. Senior guard Juan Goodwin scored 21 points for the Rams. None of his teammates scored more than nine.

St. Ignatius 76, Padua 37 The Plain Dealer's sixth-ranked team used its size advantage to open with an easy win at home. Point guard Terry Walsh had 20 points, five assists and four rebounds. Teammate Ryan Stilphen had 17 points and 10 rebounds.

Girls basketball

Chagrin Falls 42, Orange 38 With 32 seconds left and her team up by two, Brittany Anderson converted a three-point play to seal the victory for Chagrin Falls. Anderson, a junior forward, led the Tigers (2-1) with 15 points.

Orange's Chloe Queen, a senior guard, scored 15 to lead Orange (2-1).

Regina 83, Clairton Pa., 35 Regina, ranked No. 1 by The Plain Dealer, had an easy time opening its season with a win in Pennsylvania. Simone Redd and Carla Jacobs each scored 15 points to lead the Royals.

Hockey

Padua 9, Cleveland Heights 0

Senior Luke Kuchta had two goals and an assist as the Bruins cruised at the Bowling Green Thanksgiving Tournament.

Senior Tug Gulliford had two goals for Padua (1-2). Freshman Matt Feda scored one goal and had two assists, and Kevin Dickens had a goal and an assist.